

**SYNTHETIC TRAINING RECORD — FICTIONAL PARTIES, PEOPLE,
OFFICES, IDENTIFIERS, AND EVENTS — NOT A REAL FILING OR
PRESENTENCE REPORT**

Order Overruling Aggravating-Role Objection

Entered: February 24, 2026 **Synthetic docket:** SYN-MDNC-25-CR-0328 **Public docket entry:** DE39

Before the court is Mateo Serrano's objection to the proposed three-level adjustment under U.S.S.G. § 3B1.1(b). The objection was submitted January 23, addressed by Probation on January 30, answered by the government on February 6, and preserved in the February 19 defense sentencing memorandum.

For the reasons stated at the sentencing hearing and summarized here, the objection is overruled. The court finds by a preponderance that Serrano managed or supervised Alina Pared as a person for a defined portion of the charged conspiracy. Exactly five people were criminally responsible.

The order relies on abstract protected facts available to both parties. It does not reproduce the presentence report, describe transaction mechanics, disclose personal identifiers, or reveal any real record. Its public explanation identifies the legal standard, undisputed boundaries, competing inferences, and factual conclusion sufficiently to explain the adopted calculation. The court expresses no view about any future appellate issue or disposition.

Governing Standard

Section 3B1.1(b) adds three levels when the defendant was a manager or supervisor and the criminal activity involved five or more participants or was otherwise extensive. The government bears the burden of proving the adjustment by a preponderance of the evidence.

The role must include management or supervision of at least one other criminally responsible person. Management of property, assets, or activities by itself does not satisfy that person-focused requirement. See *United States v. Steffen*, 741 F.3d 411, 414–16 (4th Cir. 2013). Formal employment or direction of every participant is not invariably necessary.

The court must evaluate the relationship shown by the whole record. Knowledge, coordination, and personal importance to an offense do not automatically establish supervision. Conversely, a participant's discretion over details does not prevent a finding that another participant exercised managerial responsibility for a defined task.

The Guidelines are advisory, but the court must resolve disputed facts and correctly calculate the starting range before applying the statutory sentencing factors. The plea agreement left this role issue open and supplied no agreed enhancement.

Undisputed Factual Boundaries

Serrano pleaded guilty to conspiracy to commit wire fraud under 18 U.S.C. §§ 1349 and 1343. The charged conduct ran from August 4 through November 2, 2025, and concerned abstract false reimbursement claims for services not performed against Meridian Community Supply Cooperative. The stipulated loss and restitution figure is \$186,400.

Exactly five people were criminally responsible: Mateo Serrano, Alina Pared, Corin Bell, Darius Venn, and Nessa Holt. Serrano admits knowing participation. He does not admit managing or supervising Pared, and the plea factual basis reserved that issue.

The government relies on Pared alone as the alleged supervisee. It does not contend that Serrano managed Bell, Darius Venn, or Holt. It also disclaims any theory based solely on control of property, assets, or activities. Those shared limits keep the inquiry focused on the interpersonal inference from the protected exercise record.

The 2025 Guidelines Manual governs because the offense continued through November 2. No later legal development is required to decide this sentencing objection.

Protected Record Considered

The court considered the stipulated factual basis, the final presentence report and addendum, the defense objection, Probation's position, the government's response, the sentencing memoranda, and the parties' open argument. Confidential portions remain sealed and are described here only in abstract terms.

The relevant sequence shows Serrano identifying a defined responsibility for Pared, communicating the expected result, following up on completion, and directing correction after a departure. Those events recurred. The order deliberately omits the content and mechanics of the fictional claims because they are unnecessary to explain the role inference.

Pared retained discretion over details, was not Serrano's employee, and could decline participation. No threat, wage, formal title, or authority over all her conduct is shown. The court considered those features rather than assuming hierarchy from the existence of a conspiracy.

The record contains no authentic account information, credential, communication address, routing data, or instruction for wrongdoing. Its sealed status protects presentence material even though the exercise itself uses no real personal information. This public order states only the relationship facts essential to the adjustment ruling.

Competing Inferences

The defense characterizes Serrano's communications with Pared as requests among independent participants pursuing a shared goal. It argues that follow-up reflects coordination and knowledge, not authority. Because Pared retained choices and no formal command structure existed, the defense says the proof is at least evenly balanced.

The government characterizes the same sequence as assignment, monitoring, and correction. It argues that recurring direction concerning a defined responsibility is managerial even if Pared could decide minor details and was free to refuse. Probation adopted that interpretation in the final report.

Both parties correctly separate the numerical predicate from the role question. The existence of five participants does not itself prove that Serrano supervised one. Both also agree that management of assets alone would be insufficient.

The court gives weight to Pared's autonomy but finds the repeated combination of selection, expectation, monitoring, and corrective direction more consistent with limited supervision than equal exchange. The conclusion is narrower than a finding that Serrano organized the conspiracy or controlled all participants. It resolves only the factual issue necessary for § 3B1.1(b).

Findings and Calculation Effect

The government has proved by a preponderance that Serrano managed or supervised Alina Pared as a criminally responsible person. The finding rests on the relationship across the protected events rather than any single communication. It does not rest on ownership, control of property, or Serrano's general importance.

Because the activity involved exactly five responsible participants and Serrano supervised at least one, § 3B1.1(b) adds three levels. The resulting total offense level is 20. With criminal history category I, the advisory imprisonment range is 33 to 41 months.

Had the objection been sustained, total offense level 17 would have produced a range of 24 to 30 months. That alternative remains part of the transparent calculation record but is not adopted. Other calculation components are undisputed.

The role ruling determines the Guidelines starting point; it does not dictate the sentence. Judge Venn separately considers 18 U.S.C. § 3553(a), defense mitigation, the government's recommendation, restitution, and supervision. Nothing in this order limits the court's discretion to select a sufficient sentence after correctly calculating the range.

Conclusion and Record Direction

Serrano's objection to the three-level aggravating-role adjustment is **OVERRULED**. The court adopts the final presentence calculation at total offense level 20 and criminal history category I, with an advisory imprisonment range of 33 to 41 months.

The clerk shall associate this public order with DE39 and the February 24 hearing transcript. The underlying report, objection packet, and sentencing memoranda retain their automatic sealed status. Their public docket surrogates remain category indexes rather than redacted presentence filings.

This order is limited to the sentencing calculation in synthetic docket SYN-MDNC-25-CR-0328. It supplies no operational account of the offense, no genuine personal data, and no access to a real court or probation system. It does not decide how an appellate court might treat the role finding, any plea term, or any other alleged error.

SO ORDERED on February 24, 2026, by Judge Elara Venn. Tessa Wren shall serve the public order on Celia Arden and Bram Ives through the fictional court channel and record service without publishing contact information or credentials.